

BRUSSELS BELGIUM

Mussels in Brussels

Brussels is an hour's drive from the Belgian coast but, as a great medieval trading city, it has a historic connection with the sea. It's no surprise, therefore, that the classic Belgian dish of mussels and fries is the mainstay of many of the capital's restaurants. It's a simple, hearty, and nutritious dish that depends crucially on fresh, quality ingredients being cooked to perfection.



In 1561, an ambitious new waterway – the Willebroek Canal – was completed, leading to the heart of Brussels and giving the city a direct link to the sea. The canal terminated at Place Sainte-Catherine, a stone's throw from the city's splendid centerpiece, the Grand Place. In the late 19th century, when the canal's course was diverted and the basins at the city's center filled in, the area became the site of a huge fish market, the Marché aux Poissons. The fish market has since disappeared, but the connection with the sea remains in the wonderful fish restaurants of Place Sainte-Catherine.

Belgium has acquired a dizzying reputation for good food in recent decades, and its capital is also the effective capital of the European Union, attracting a cosmopolitan crowd that demands high standards. In the Belgians themselves, a culture of good food is instilled from an early age: they like to eat well, but have little tolerance of pretension. *Moules-frites* (mussels and fries) falls into this tradition. The high-end restaurants here are too grand to serve such

a simple dish, and you're more likely to find it in bistros and family restaurants, but *moules-frites* is not to be sniffed at. It's a simple enough dish: the mussels are usually cooked *marinière* (steamed with chopped shallots, celery, parsley, thyme, bay leaves, and a glass of white wine), then served in large casseroles accompanied by copious *frites* (fries). But its creation en masse in lively restaurants creates glorious scenes reminiscent of the festive village celebrations painted by Pieter Brueghel the Elder, a resident of Brussels in the mid-16th century.

There is plenty for the visitor to see and admire in Brussels, including a fine cathedral and excellent art museums. But the real joy of visiting the city lies in glimpsing something of its individual character, which nurtured the Surrealist vision of René Magritte, and gave birth to Art Nouveau architecture and Tintin, the famous cartoon reporter. In the same spirit, the Belgian artist Marcel Broodthaers produced his most famous sculptural work in 1964–6 in several versions. His *Grande Casserole de Moules* is just what it says – real mussel shells filling a blackened casserole.



Above The old district of Les Marolles is renowned for its comic-strip murals



The Best Places to Eat Moules-Frites

La Marée moderate

Portuguese-born Mario and Teresa Alves have been building a solid reputation for delicious fish for over 30 years. Their restaurant's name means "The Tide," and the pretty 17th-century red-brick building is full of seafaring memorabilia, alongside old photos of the Marché aux Poissons. But essentially an easy simplicity prevails, so clients can concentrate on the food concocted by Teresa and her team in a kitchen open to view. It is a perfect setting for *moules-frites*: hospitable, unpretentious, yet with careful attention to detail. Prepared in four different ways (*marinière*, *au vin blanc*, *à la provençale*, and *maison*), the mussels come to the table in large, cast-iron casseroles. You can dig them out of their shells with a fork or by using an empty pair of shells as pincers; then drink the cooking juices with a spoon. Simple, beautifully done, and classically Belgian.

Rue de Flandre 99, Brussels; open 12–2 PM and 6:30–10 PM Tue–Sat; www.lamaree-sa.com

Also in Brussels

In't Spinnepokke (www.spinnekopke.be; *moderate*) is a delightfully atmospheric *estaminet* (traditional tavern) dating back to 1762 that specializes in Belgian beers and dishes, including *moules-frites*. **Chez Patrick** (www.chezpatrick.be; *moderate*) is another splendidly traditional eatery close to the Grand Place that has been serving *Bruxellois* favorites including *moules-frites* for over 70 years.

Also in Belgium

Go to the coast to sample some really delicious mussels and other seafoods. **Oesterput** (www.oesterput.com; *moderate*) stands right by the harbor at Blankenberge, and this workmanlike warehouse with a cafeteria-style restaurant serves first-class seafood of all kinds.

A l'Improviste (www.a-l-improviste.be; *moderate*) is a stylish, modern seafood restaurant with a terrace overlooking the sea at Knokke-Heist that serves classic dishes such as *moules-frites* with great flair.

Around the World

The high international reputation of Belgian cooking has spawned outposts abroad in numerous formats. London has the **Belgo** chain (www.belgo-restaurants.co.uk; *moderate*) – brasserie-style restaurants specializing in Belgian dishes and beer. There are two **Belgian Beer Cafés** (www.belgianbeercafemelbourne.com; *moderate*) with a similar mission in Melbourne, Australia. Elsewhere, look for restaurants specializing in authentic Belgian cuisine. **Jeannine's Bistro** (www.jeanninesbistro.com; *moderate*) in Houston, Texas, is a fine example.

Les Frites Belges

Belgian *frites* (French fries) set the gold standard: when properly prepared, there are simply no better fries in the world. There are several factors involved. First, the choice of potato: only certain varieties (such as Bintje) are sufficiently sweet and floury to produce the optimum flavor and crispness. Second, the chips must be cut into just the right shape – about the size of a woman's little finger. Third, the oil (traditionally beef dripping) must be clean and piping hot. Lastly – and crucially – the *frites* are cooked twice: once to a pale softness; then, after cooling and resting, to a crispy, golden finish. The traditional Belgian accompaniment is mayonnaise. In Brussels, perfection is achieved not just in restaurants, but also in humble roadside stands (called *friteries* or *frietkoten*). A cornet of hot *frites* and a dollop of mayonnaise can be a meal in itself.